

chip-level problems for my friends", says Rahul Mehra. Rahul then moved on to opening up and fixing discarded CRT monitors and is now known as "The Fixer" in his circles. So do you have to be technically qualified? Not really. There are enough resources available online to get anyone started. There are even kits to help amateurs get started. DIY portable amplifier kits such as CMoy or Mini3 are very popular in audiophile circles, for instance. Web sites such as [ifixit.com](http://ifixit.com) put up well-documented repair guides and beautiful high-res photographs of gadgets that they tear down. Gawking at naked beauties has never been so SFW. The latest wave of console hacking (some of which we've covered in past issues) is just another form of the DIY culture. Follow the link to learn more. <<http://bit.ly/cultldiy>>

## Hacktivism

When the freedom of the internet is under threat, there rises a breed of socially conscious hackers who stand up to protect the rights of the free world. These are geeks with a cause and the necessary skills to retaliate against tyrannical powers that be who seek to limit the freedom of ordinary netizens. They're white-hat hackers, with noble intentions of social change but their actions are certainly illegal. These



Anonymous. Who are they?

include web site defacements, redirects, denial-of-service (DDoS) attacks and other's mischief. In recent times Anonymous, who normally are interested in their daily Lulz, launched a series of DDoS attacks on US government web sites in protest of SOPA. Now this isn't a sub-culture we necessarily condone, but what we're trying to say is that geeks are socially aware, take up causes and make their voices heard in the face of injustice.

Apart from these misunderstood miscreants, much of the tech world turned hacktivists in their own ways. Apart from biggies such as Wikipedia and Google,

many blogs posted anti-SOPA messages of their own and the geek universe galvanised united towards a common cause. Such is the power of hacktivism.

## From the shadows to the forefront

The other side of pontificating online (read sharing knowledge) is lurking around in cyberspace. Lurking is basically visiting online message boards, forums, and other virtual setups like chat rooms and IRC channels and simply reading without posting anything of your own. In the dictionary sense, lurking has a negative meaning alluding to lying in wait with an intent to ambush. Online lurking doesn't necessarily have a negative connotation. Unless of course you consider the new breed of social networking lurking, but for that you have another word, stalking.

Lurking as a culture is a proactive choice or, at times, a necessity. It's a necessity when newbies try to break into a community and seem out of place. Hence it's often advised that new entrants into any culture lurk for a while, get familiar with the culture, the specific lingo, nuances and then begin to contribute. Being reticent is better than posting nonsense after all. Lurking in forums is common but a newer type of lurking that's emerging is on article comment threads and even YouTube videos. Lurkers often spend as much time on YouTube comments as watching the actual videos. By doing this they get exposed to the brand of humour prevalent on YouTube's community. Ironical comments such as "I'm in the weird part of YouTube again" or "How did I get here" or "I get no thumbs ups" usually get a lot of likes.

So what are the advantages of lurking? Knowledge is one, and since you've spent time understanding a community, you get better acceptance once you start posting. Another advantage is the lingo and jargon you come across. Lots of people who seem witty online have only just regurgitated something that they've come across in their endless lurking. But hey, if it works for newer platforms such as Twitter, then, why not! You get an instant rise in the social pecking order and follower counts. Places such as Twitter don't follow the one per cent rule very strictly. The rule (and it applies to forums) states that only one percent of people actually

create content, nine percent contribute to that content and the majority lurk. On Twitter and other social media, content is created by a much larger percentage of users. It may not necessarily be read but it still adds to the competition. So go ahead lurk, gain expertise and then come out with all guns blazing.

## Start-up culture

It goes without saying that geeks have always been at the forefront of the start-up culture. Whether it's billion dollar companies in Silicon Valley or even web services based out of Bangalore, start-ups is now a culture amongst entrepreneurial geeks. For the uninitiated, a start-up is a high growth, low capital and technology oriented venture. Start-ups can be web services, software companies or just about anything. Since start-ups are usually associated with technology, geeks are the ones establishing themselves in this culture. After all, looking at the success of role models (and fellow geeks) such as Steve Jobs, Bill Gates and Mark Zuckerberg, who wouldn't want to put up a start-up of their own? The risks are many and success rate is very low but the rewards are high. Since innovation is a fundamental paradigm of this culture, you need to be of that bent of mind. If you like improving things and understand underlying technologies well, perhaps you should give this culture a shot. If it's a web start-up you have in mind, the investment is also not very large. For funding as well there are several business plan competitions happening at the college level. At the time of scaling up, there are many resources (even in India) such as VCs, Incubators etc. which will come of use if your product has potential. Stay in the loop, collaborate with other geeks and maybe you could be the next big thing. Head over to <<http://bit.ly/cultstartup>> to get started.

## Memes

A meme can be loosely defined as anything that catches the fancy of netizens for some unknown reason and gets